Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

Usually, we use the food stamps we receive to buy what we need, and when the food stamps run out, we wait for the next payment to come. We often only take as much as we need.

a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

We couldn’t always buy meat or rice, and we couldn't get things that my kids liked. We could only buy the very essential items, just enough for what we needed. For six months the food was cut off. We went to the DWS and applied several times, but we were rejected each time until finally, in January it was approved.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

All the trips. We made it to DWS and were fruitless then we borrowed money from our friends and bought groceries. Gradually, we paid them back.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

They didn't help at all. Many of the people sitting in the office just waste their time. They tell you to fill out this form and that form, but they don’t do anything. All these trips are fruitless; they only give empty promises about helping. At most, they provide a few addresses for food assistance, but when you are there, they give expired items or things that are not suitable.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

They applied for my green card, and they didn't do anything else.

d. Can you tell me when food became a problem?

When the food stamps were cut off and I was pregnant, it was very difficult. The nutritious foods that I needed during that time didn’t reach me. We went to DWS several times and applied, but it was all in vain.

i. You indicated that you have used the WIC program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

We heard that the WIC program accepts children under five, so I went there to register. They gave us a card, and each month, a specific amount of food was provided. We got to know about it through friends, and applying for the program was very easy.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program?
iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

2. They provide dairy products, fruits, and other food items, but not meat. It only works at Smith's and WinCo; it doesn't work anywhere else. It's good, but the quantity of the food is limited.
    i. What % of your foods come from this program?

It covers only 5% of the family's food needs.

ii. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

We didn't have any information about it.

iii. : Have you asked your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you because they help refugees find food resources?

We applied for the food stamps ourselves; they only for our green card, applying for food stamps was easy for us, it was not difficult.

iv. : Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

3. We said for the IRC, but they told us to go to DWS. However, when we went there, they still rejected us.

a. You indicated that in the last 12 months, you often/always worried that the food you were able to eat would hurt your health and well-being, can you tell me more?

On the one hand, my children needed food, and on the other hand, I was pregnant. Every time we went, they would tell us to wait or that our case was under review. The review process for everything we sent the document they requested, was frustrating. They kept saying they didn't receive it and asked us to resend it. This was very stressful for us, especially take and we feared that they would close our case again for three or four months.

4. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

In our culture, we purchase everything we need from halal markets that cater to our community. They usually have Afghan shops, and we buy from those places.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

100 % important

b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

We usually buy vegetables from WinCo because their prices are cheaper.

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

They didn't help at all.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview, and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

Afghans go to the IRC to discuss their problems, but they don't pay attention at all. At that moment, they say they are looking into it and will apply, but the stuff members always claim they are in the meetings or out or in lunch. When we finally find them, they say they know nothing. This causes many immigrants to feel disconnected from the programs.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

When someone encounters a problem, they go to say, 'I have this issue if these problems are addressed quickly, the government will also understand what issues exist. The same staff members should report to the government that there is a specific problem. However, these employees don't communicate properly with the government, which leads to the people missing out on assistance instead of helping people to quickly address their needs, they don't take the time to listen, causing many to fall behind in these support programs,

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

The government needs to remind all their employees, wherever come in. There should be an organization where they can see that the staff are not doing their jobs properly. People should be able to go to that organization and speak. 'We have these problems, and our issues are not being addressed.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Usually, food service can at least provide something; we can buy from Afghan shops. Families like ours need diapers, but the IRC says they don't have any. We have never received diapers for our children from the IRC or any assistance at all. The IRC has not helped us.